Muslim warriors, like the cavalry of 10,000 ‘Turks’ recruited by Deva Raya II in 1430. Krishnadevaraya reconquered Raichur in 1520 with help from Portuguese musketeers. Many elite warriors—Hindu, Muslim and Christian—were mercenaries and often changed sides. In short, ‘loyalty to family, faction, or paymaster counted for more than loyalty to land, religion, or ethnic group’, writes Richard M. Eaton, a social historian of the Deccan.[9] The primary drivers of war in this age too were the imperatives of power, territory and resources, variously entangled with religion and ideology.

